

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 46

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: Uncle Heng, a wet-market vegetable seller, is caught by a sudden monsoon downpour, and an old customer quietly shelters at the stall and lends a hand.

1

The first warning came not from the sky but from the gutters. Uncle Heng was rearranging a tray of choy sum when he heard the high, complaining whistle of water already rushing through the drains at the back of the wet market. He looked up. The strip of sky above the corrugated roof had turned the colour of wet slate. Two stalls down, the fishmonger's wife was shouting at her son to bring the tarpaulin. Uncle Heng said nothing. He simply set down the bunch of greens in his hand, wiped his palms on the front of his apron, and began.

2

There is a particular order in which a vegetable stall must be saved. The leafy greens go first, because they bruise; the root vegetables, hardier, can wait. He worked quickly but not in a hurry, the way a man works when he has done the same thing for thirty-one years. Crates were lifted, slid, stacked. The price cards, hand-lettered in red marker on cardboard, were tucked face-down under the weighing scale so the ink would not run. Only when he reached for the canvas sheet above his head did the first heavy drops begin, fat and slow, like coins thrown one by one onto the metal roof.

3

Then, all at once, the sky opened. The rain came down in a single sheet, so thick that the stall opposite vanished into a grey blur. Within seconds the floor of the market was an inch deep in water, and the leftover cabbage leaves swept along it like little green boats. Uncle Heng tugged at the canvas. It was old and stiff, and one of the corner ropes had knotted itself sometime during the dry weeks before. He pulled, swore softly under his breath, and pulled again.

4

A pair of hands appeared beside his on the rope. He did not need to look to know whose they were. Mrs

Tan had bought her morning vegetables from him every Tuesday and Friday for more than twenty years; he knew her hands the way he knew his own knife. She had stepped under the eaves of the stall to escape the downpour and, without a word being asked or given, had reached up to help. Together they worked the knot free. The canvas dropped, the rain drummed on it, and the stall, suddenly, was dry.

5

It was only then that Uncle Heng remembered the money-pouch. He kept it on a hook at the side of the wooden stand, a soft leather thing worn smooth by years of thumbs. The hook was, he saw with a sinking feeling, exactly under the seam where the old canvas had been leaking. The pouch was sodden. He opened it and laid the notes out, one by one, on the dry corner of the weighing scale: a fifty, two tens, a small flock of two-dollar bills, all of them limp and dark with rain. He set the coins aside in a pile that made a small, apologetic sound.

6

Mrs Tan, without speaking, took a clean square of newspaper from her shopping basket and began to press it gently over the notes, the way one might blot ink. Uncle Heng watched her do this for a moment, and then went back to checking the crates. Neither of them said anything about the weather. Neither of them said anything about the helping. To make a fuss of it would have made it smaller than it was. Outside the canvas the rain went on with its enormous, indifferent voice.

7

A strange peace settled on the little stall. The market, which on a normal Tuesday morning would have been clamorous with bargaining and the clack of wooden chopping blocks, was muted now; everyone was waiting, and waiting together. Uncle Heng felt the deep familiar ache in his lower back, the one that always came when he had been crouching among the crates, and he was, oddly, glad of it. It told him he had got the vegetables in. It told him the day, in spite of everything, had been done properly.

8

When the rain at last began to thin, Mrs Tan smoothed her dress, picked up her basket, and chose, with great care, a single bunch of kang kong from the surviving stack. She paid him with a coin from her own purse, although he had tried, weakly, to wave it away. “Tomorrow also have, or not?” she asked. He nodded. She nodded back. She walked out into the lifting drizzle, and Uncle Heng stood for a long time afterwards looking at the wet, tidy stall, and at the place on the rope where her hand had been beside his.

From Paragraph 1

1. Explain, in your own words, why the writer says the “first warning came not from the sky but from the gutters.” [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show Uncle Heng reacted to the coming storm calmly rather than in a panic. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The writer says Uncle Heng “worked quickly but not in a hurry, the way a man works when he has done the same thing for thirty-one years.” Explain what this sentence tells us about his approach to his work. [2]

4. The first drops of rain are compared to “coins thrown one by one onto the metal roof.” Explain what is **effective** about this comparison. [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. Pick out **one** word or phrase from Paragraph 3 which shows that the rain fell **suddenly and heavily**, and explain your choice. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The writer says of Mrs Tan that Uncle Heng “knew her hands the way he knew his own knife.”

- (a) What does this comparison suggest about how long he has known her? [1]
(b) What does it suggest about how he sees her — as a stranger, a customer, or something else? [1]

7. The writer says of the helping that it happened “without a word being asked or given.” Explain what this phrase tells us about the relationship between Uncle Heng and Mrs Tan. [2]

From Paragraph 5

8. The coins make “a small, apologetic sound.” What does the word **apologetic** suggest about Uncle Heng’s feelings at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The writer says: “To make a fuss of it would have made it smaller than it was.” Explain, in your own words, what this sentence means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The writer says that Uncle Heng felt his back ache and was “oddly, glad of it.” Why does he describe this gladness as **odd**? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the hidden environmental cost of bottled water.****1**

For an industry built on the idea of purity, bottled water has a remarkably murky environmental record. Globally, consumers now buy more than one million plastic bottles every minute, a figure that has roughly doubled in the past fifteen years. The product is marketed as natural, healthy and convenient, and most of us, when we reach for a chilled bottle at the petrol station or the school tuck shop, give little thought to what has happened upstream of that reach. The trouble is that everything that has happened upstream — the extraction, the bottling, the freight, the refrigeration — carries a cost that is paid not at the till but by the climate, by the oceans, and increasingly by our own bodies.

2

Begin with the carbon. A 2021 review in the journal **Science of the Total Environment** estimated that producing, transporting and chilling one litre of bottled water emits, on average, between 0.2 and 0.3 kilograms of carbon dioxide equivalent. Tap water, by contrast, emits less than one thousandth of that figure. The bottle itself, almost always made of polyethylene terephthalate, is fashioned from oil; the cap requires a separate plastic; the label requires a third. The bottle is then shipped, sometimes across continents, in a refrigerated lorry, and the lorry, of course, runs on diesel. By the time the bottle reaches the supermarket shelf, it has accumulated a carbon footprint several hundred times that of the same volume drawn from a kitchen tap.

3

The plastic itself is a second, more insidious problem. A 2024 study by researchers at Columbia and Rutgers, using a new laser-imaging technique, found that the average litre of commercially bottled water contained around 240,000 fragments of plastic, of which the great majority were nanoplastics — particles small enough to cross the gut wall and enter the bloodstream. Earlier studies had estimated only a few thousand particles per litre; the new figure is roughly a hundred times higher. The health consequences are not yet fully understood, but nanoplastics have been detected in human placentas, lungs and brains, and have been linked, in early studies, to inflammation and to disruption of the endocrine system.

4

Stranger still is the fact that much of this is happening in countries where the tap water is already perfectly safe. In Singapore, the United Kingdom, Germany, Japan and most of the Nordic nations, municipal water is tested several times a day and meets standards as strict as, or stricter than, those applied to commercial mineral water. Surveys consistently find, however, that consumers in these countries continue to **believe** that bottled is purer. The belief is the product of forty years of careful marketing — the mountain stream, the snow-capped peak, the word **spring** — and not of any measurable difference at the molecular level.

5

A handful of European cities have begun to push back, and the results have been instructive. Paris, since 2018, has installed more than 1,200 free, sparkling-water fountains across its arrondissements; bottled-water sales in supermarkets within the city have fallen by an estimated 14 per cent. Berlin has gone further, banning single-use plastic bottles from municipal events. The European Union itself, through its 2020 Drinking Water Directive, now obliges member states to **promote** tap water in public buildings — a small linguistic shift, but one that has begun to alter procurement decisions across the continent. None of these measures, on their own, will rescue the planet; in combination, however, they redraw what is considered the default choice.

6

There is, of course, a place for bottled water. After a flood, an earthquake, or a contamination scare, a

sealed bottle is a public-health necessity, and the industry deserves credit for the speed with which it can mobilise in such moments. There are also parts of the world where the tap is not, and may never be, a safe source; bottled water in those places is not a lifestyle choice but a literal lifeline. The argument is not that the bottle has no place. The argument is that, in wealthy nations with safe public supplies, it has come to occupy a vastly larger place than it deserves.

7

What, then, can be done? Individuals can carry a refillable bottle and refill it; this single habit, repeated, will spare the planet hundreds of bottles a year per person. Local councils can install drinking fountains in parks, schools and transport hubs. Employers can stop stocking single-use bottles in meeting rooms. Schools can return to the once-ordinary practice of teaching children to drink from a tap. None of these acts is dramatic. None of them is, taken alone, sufficient. Yet the bottle that is not bought is the only bottle that costs the planet nothing — and the steady, unspectacular work of not buying it, multiplied across a city, is what change in this matter looks like.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that bottled water has “a remarkably murky environmental record.” Explain why he describes this record as **murky**. [2]

13. What is the writer’s purpose in listing “the extraction, the bottling, the freight, the refrigeration”? [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why a single bottle of water accumulates such a large carbon footprint. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer calls plastic contamination a “second, more insidious problem.” Explain, in your own words, what **insidious** suggests about this problem. [2]

16. The 2024 study found “roughly a hundred times” more plastic particles per litre than earlier studies. Why does the writer draw attention to this comparison? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. Why does the writer call it “stranger still” that bottled water is consumed in countries with safe tap water? [2]

18. Explain, in your own words, what the writer means when he says the consumer’s belief is “the product of forty years of careful marketing... and not of any measurable difference at the molecular level.” [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. Give **two** specific measures, from Paragraph 5, that European cities or institutions have taken to reduce bottled-water consumption. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. What does the writer concede about bottled water in Paragraph 6, and why does he include this concession? [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says, “None of these acts is dramatic. None of them is, taken alone, sufficient.” What is the **effect** of these two short sentences? [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the environmental and health costs of bottled water**, and **what can be done to reduce its consumption**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 5 and 7** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Bottled water harms the planet and the body because ...

— END OF PAPER —